

How Digging and Cutting Trees Hurt Animals and Plants

Living things need safe homes to eat, sleep, and raise their babies. Some animals live high in the treetops. Some plants grow on steep rock walls. Other animals live down in the dirt or swim in rivers.

Sometimes, people use big machines to dig rocks and metals out of the ground. This is called mining. People also cut down forests to make roads and open dirt pits. When people dig big holes and chop down trees, they break the homes of many amazing animals and plants.

Here is what happens to nature when big machines change the land.

1. The Island of Hispaniola

Hispaniola is a sunny island in the sea. It is home to many rare animals and plants that live nowhere else on Earth. But big trucks dig up rocks to make cement, and mines dig deep pits to find metal.

Living Thing	What It Is	Why It Needs Help
Hispaniolan Trogon	A colorful bird	Big machines cut down its favorite dead trees
Least Pauraque	A bird that hides on the ground	Digging scoops away the rocks and leaves it hides under
Hispaniolan Solenodon	A furry creature with a long nose	Bulldozers crush its underground home
Oviedo's Cherry Palm	A slow-growing palm tree	Big diggers smash the rocks where it grows
Bayahibe Rose	A rare bush cactus with pink flowers	Machines scrape away the rocky ground where it holds on
Hispaniolan Pine	A tall mountain pine tree	Strip mines take away the rich dirt so baby trees cannot grow

The Hispaniolan Trogon

The Hispaniolan Trogon is a bird with a bright green back and a red belly. It cannot dig a nest in hard, new wood. It needs soft, old, dead trees called snags. When mines cut down the mountain trees, these dead trees are lost. This bird is afraid to fly across big, empty dirt pits. When the forest is cut, it cannot find fruits or bugs, and it cannot raise its chicks.



The Least Pauraque

The Least Pauraque is a quiet bird that rests on the ground during the day. Its brown feathers look just like dead leaves and rocks. This camouflage keeps it safe from hungry hunters. When workers dig up limestone rocks to make cement, they scrape the ground down to flat stone. The bird has nowhere to hide its eggs, and the bugs it eats disappear.



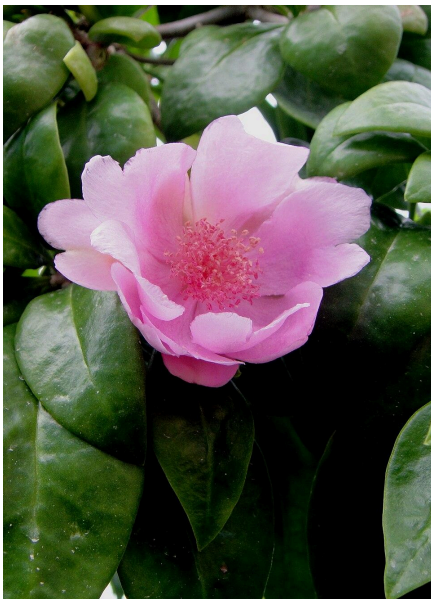
The Hispaniolan Solenodon



The Hispaniolan Solenodon looks like a large shrew with a long, wiggly nose. It uses its nose to sniff out bugs in the soft soil. During the day, it sleeps in long tunnels under the dirt and rocks. When heavy bulldozers roll over the ground, they crush the tunnels and trap the solenodons inside. Mining also scrapes away the wet soil, leaving no food to eat. New roads bring pet dogs into the woods that hunt the solenodons.



Oviedo's Cherry Palm: This funny palm has a round belly and grows slowly on hard limestone rocks. When quarries dig out stone, they smash the adult palms and destroy the little rock pockets where baby seeds sprout.



Bayahibe Rose: This is a rare cactus that has pretty pink flowers and real green leaves. It only grows in a few rocky spots near the sea. Digging machines and rock blasting scrape away the stony ground it clings to.

Hispaniolan Pine: These tall pine trees cover high, cold mountains. Their roots need helpful forest mushrooms in the dirt to stay healthy. When open-pit mines dig up the mountain, they remove all the soil. Without soil and mushrooms, new pine trees cannot grow back.



2. The Tall Rainforests in Suriname

The Amazon and the Guiana Shield are giant rainforests with very tall trees and rocky hills. Many animals spend their whole lives high up in the green leaves. But gold mines, bauxite mines, and logging roads cut large paths through the trees.

Living Thing	What It Is	Why It Needs Help
Harpy Eagle	A giant forest eagle	It cannot find food for its chick when too many trees are gone
Guianan Cock-of-the-Rock	A bright orange bird	Rock blasting breaks its cliff nests and scares it away
Margay	A small spotted cat	It will not cross open dirt roads, so it gets trapped
Clump Wallaba	A large rainforest tree	Mines cut down whole groves and dry out the ground
Marsh Pitcher Plant	A plant that eats bugs	Digging takes away its wet, spongy moss
Sand Baromalli	A tall tree by the river	Gold dredges wash away the riverbanks under its roots

The Harpy Eagle



The Harpy Eagle is one of the largest eagles on the planet. It makes huge nests in the tallest trees of the rainforest. It flies through the treetops to hunt sloths and monkeys. When mines and loggers cut down trees, the sloths and monkeys disappear. Scientists found that if people cut down more than half of the forest, the mother and father eagle cannot find enough food, and their baby chick can starve in the nest.]

The Guianan Cock-of-the-Rock

The male Guianan Cock-of-the-Rock has bright orange feathers. Groups of males clear spots on the forest floor and dance to impress females. The mother birds build nests made of mud on steep, rocky cliffs and cave walls. When companies blast rock with dynamite to get stone, they break the cliffs into pieces. The loud noises also scare the birds away from their dancing spots.



The Margay

The Margay is a small wildcat with big eyes and a long tail. It has special ankles that can turn all the way around backwards. This lets the margay run straight down tree trunks like a squirrel. The margay spends most of its time hunting in the branches. When mines make wide dirt roads, the margay is too afraid to walk on the ground to cross them. Families of cats get stuck in small patches of trees and cannot find enough food.



Clump Wallaba: These big hardwood trees grow close together on white sand soils. When mines clear them away, the hot sun bakes the bare ground. This dries up the special fungi in the soil that baby trees need to survive.





Marsh Pitcher Plant: This plant looks like a green pitcher cup that holds water to catch bugs. It lives in wet, spongy moss on top of high, foggy mountains. When miners dig for diamonds and gold, they scrape away the moss and change the water flow, causing the plants to dry out and die.

Baromalli: This tree grows on riverbanks and holds the soil in place with its roots. Gold mining machines spray strong water jets and scoop up river dirt. This washes away the ground under the trees, making the riverbanks collapse into the water.



3. Rivers and Dry Valleys in Bolivia

Bolivia has deep rivers, flat grassy plains that flood with water, and dry rocky canyons. Digging for gold in the water and quarrying rocks in the canyons hurts the wildlife that lives there.

Living Thing	What It Is	Why It Needs Help
Bolivian River Dolphin	A pink freshwater dolphin	Mining dredges make the water noisy, muddy, and toxic
Blue-throated Macaw	A rare blue and yellow parrot	Digging canals and gravel dries out its nesting palms
Red-fronted Macaw	A green parrot with red patches	Dynamite blasting breaks its cliff-side nest holes
Golden Rat Tail Cactus	A furry golden cliff cactus	Rock cutting and road blasting smash its home
Cardenasiodendron Tree	A tough dry-valley tree	Digging up gravel strips away the dirt around its deep roots
Queñua de Altura	A little tree on cold mountains	Metal mines bulldoze its rocky home and freeze its roots

The Bolivian River Dolphin

The Bolivian River Dolphin is a pink dolphin that lives only in the rivers of Bolivia. It makes clicking sounds underwater and listens for the echoes to "see" where it is going and to find fish. Big mining boats use loud motors and suction tubes to pull up gravel from the



river bottom to find gold. This makes the water very muddy and noisy, so the dolphin cannot hear its clicks. Gold miners also use a dangerous chemical called mercury. The mercury washes into the river, gets into the fish, and makes the dolphins sick.

The Blue-throated Macaw

The Blue-throated Macaw is a rare parrot that lives on little clumps of trees called "forest islands" in wet grassy plains. It eats fruit from the Motacú palm tree and nests inside hollow trunks. When people dig up gravel for roads or dig big ditches to drain away the water, the soil dries out. Without water, old palm trees die and new ones cannot grow, leaving the macaws with no place to raise their babies.

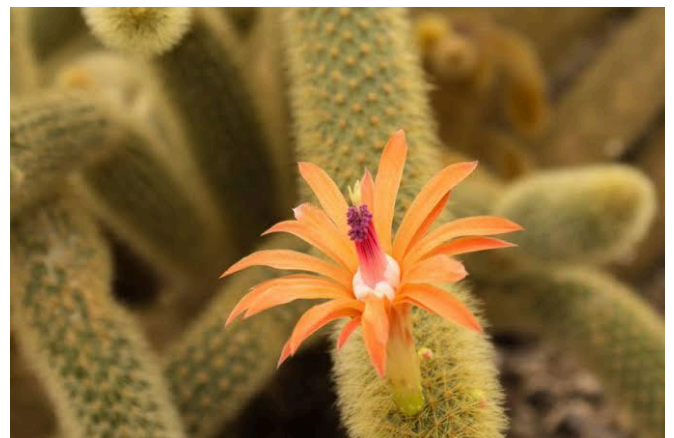


The Red-fronted Macaw



The Red-fronted Macaw lives in dry, warm canyons. Instead of nesting in trees, it builds its nests inside cracks on steep sandstone cliffs. When workers blast the cliffs with dynamite to make roads or dig sand from the river below, the cliffs crumble. The explosions break open the nest holes and destroy the bushes where the macaws find seeds and berries to eat.

Golden Rat Tail Cactus: This cactus has soft golden bristles and hangs like a tail from sandstone cliffs. When workers cut rock or use dynamite, the cliffs break and crush the cacti.





Cardenasiodendron Tree: This tree grows in dry river valleys by sending deep roots down into the soil to find water. When people dig out river gravel, they scrape away the soil and hurt the tree's roots.

Queñua de Altura: This dwarf tree lives high up in the freezing cold mountains. It keeps its roots warm under a thick carpet of green moss. When metal mines scrape away the rocks and moss for roads, the roots freeze in the cold mountain air.



4. How We Can Protect Animals and Plants

All of these animals and plants need healthy homes to survive. People can help protect them by doing these things:

1. **Stop digging in national parks:** Keep big machines and rock quarries away from the places where rare animals sleep and nest.
2. **Leave plenty of tall trees:** Keep large areas of the forest connected so eagles, cats, and birds can fly and climb safely.
3. **Keep rivers clean:** Stop using dangerous mercury in gold mining so water stays clean for dolphins and fish.
4. **Protect nesting cliffs:** Stop using dynamite near river canyons where rare parrots lay their eggs.

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